



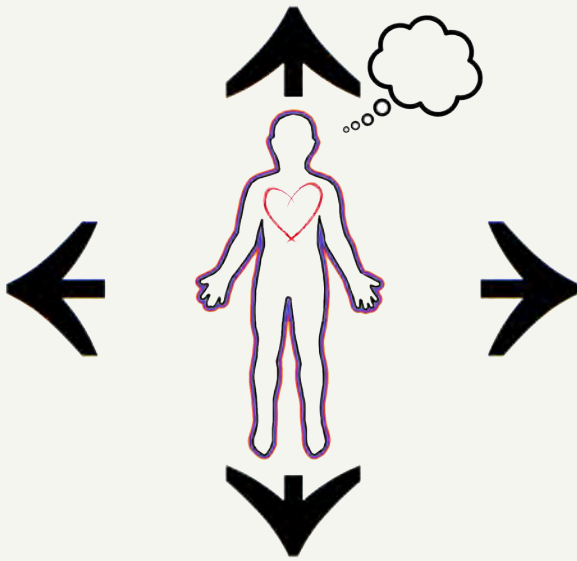
COMING TO OUR SENSES

Your Guide to the Course



THEATR CYNEFIN

PART I: A NEW APPROACH



Welcome to this guide for *Coming to Our Senses*.

In this first section, you'll find an overview of the key elements that make up the course.

In short, *Coming to Our Senses* combines mindfulness practices, creative challenges, and group dialogue to support mental health and wellbeing. This guide is designed to accompany the in-person course, led by a trained facilitator. It is not a standalone resource and may not make sense on its own.

You may have some experience with mindfulness or be a mindfulness practitioner. You might be an artist or enjoy creative hobbies. Whatever your background, approach this course with an open mind. Creative mindfulness is less about making art and more about exploring the art of observing ourselves.

CONTENT

1. INTRODUCTION
2. CONTEXT ORIENTED ARTS
3. HOME PRACTICE
4. THE FLOW JOURNAL SYSTEM
5. FLOW JOURNAL TEMPLATE



INTRODUCTION

Who or what killed our peace? This is the *murder mystery* we set out to explore in this course. Why do we feel uncomfortable simply being with ourselves, without distraction? What is the source of this agitation? So often, we attempt to outsource the source, medicate the symptoms and soldier on without ever addressing the root of the dis-ease. Our efforts to cover up the crime may work for a while, but eventually, we run out of moves.

While there is whimsy in this invitation, it is *criminal* how much of our short time on earth is spent preoccupied with elsewhere—lost in hopes for better days or trapped in regret and nostalgia. When we are caught up in and at the effect of what *is not*, we miss *what is*. But what if all there is *is this*? An what if '*this*' is not at all what we think it is?

The game is afoot.

CONTEXT ORIENTED ARTS

Not only does consciousness resemble a theater but, as Artaud constructs it, theater resembles consciousness, and therefore lends itself to being turned into a theater-laboratory in which to conduct research in changing consciousness.

- Susan Sontag

This course is delivered through Context Oriented Arts (CoArts), a method developed by Iwan Brioc over 30 years of directing immersive theatre, facilitating applied theatre, and teaching mindfulness. CoArts suggests that the arts, particularly theatre, can reveal our true nature—not by creating content to experience, but by reflecting the context of experience itself.



The course takes a four-pronged approach:

Mindfulness

Most mindfulness programs follow the MBSR template set by Jon Kabat-Zinn 40 years ago—before iPhones, the attention economy, social media, and AI reshaped both our brains and the world they now navigate. While staying true to the principles of a Mindfulness-Based Intervention, this course uses *skilful means* to create experiential and embodied learning—what we call *glimpses*!

Creativity

These *glimpses* arise through Creative Challenges, which form the core of each session, bookended by guided meditation followed by open and non-judgemental group dialogue to unpack what just happened. What the glimpses reveal is our true nature—something far beyond what we think we are.

Flow

First identified by Mihaly Csikszentmihalyi, flow is a state of deep absorption where time and self-consciousness fade—something he observed in artists lost in their craft. This course introduces a unique journaling method developed by Sarah Gregg that not only captures insights but integrates them to drive real behavioral change, making flow a lived experience rather than just a concept.

Non-duality

Underpinning all of this is something called non-duality which simply means not two! When you dream at night, everything in the dream—people, places, even "you"—seems separate, but upon waking, you realise it was all coming from the same mind. Non-duality suggests that waking life is no different—everything arises from and is made of the same consciousness.

HOME PRACTICE



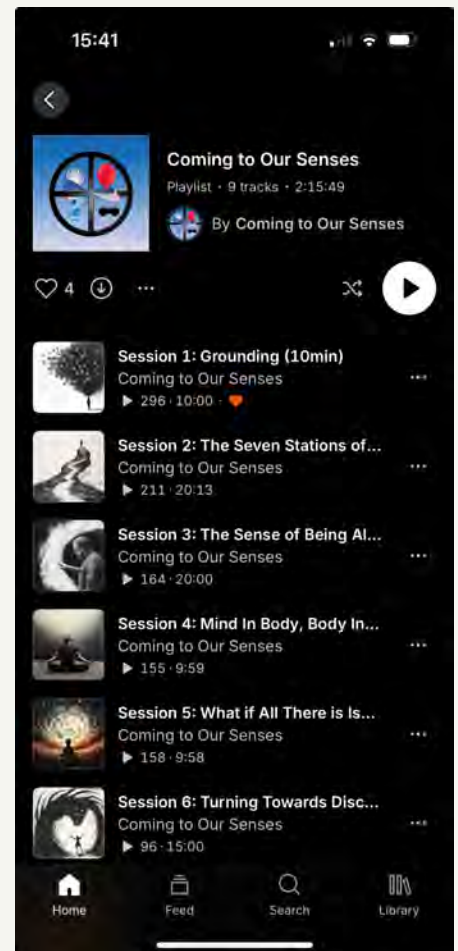
Guided Meditations

To ensure this course has a lasting positive impact on your mental health and well-being, regular home practice is essential.

The guided meditations are designed to help you integrate the glimpses of your true nature that the creative challenges reveal.

To access them, simply scan the QR code at the top of this page with your smartphone camera. This will take you to a SoundCloud playlist containing all the guided meditations for this course.

If you don't have the SoundCloud app, you'll need to download it and create a free account. If you need assistance, speak with your trainer, who can help set it up during a session.



Handy Hacks

Each week, we introduce practical handy hacks—shorter practices or mindset shifts you can use throughout the day. These help to embed new behaviors, values, and skills, supporting your ability to stay calm and composed, focused and compassionate—both in the best of times and the most challenging moments.

Journalling for Flow

Throughout our journey together, we'll introduce you to the Flow Journal system, developed by psychologist Sarah Gregg.

While keeping a journal during the course is beneficial, using this structured approach will help you integrate what you've learned into lasting, transformative change.

You'll need a plain notebook for this practice, and later in this guide, we'll explain how to divide each page for optimal use.



THE FLOW JOURNAL SYSTEM

BY SARAH GREGG

Flow occurs when thoughts, feelings and actions are in harmony. In flow we shed the conditions of who we 'should be' and increasingly align with our authentic selves. Flow is our guiding force that helps us return to a deep sense of wholeness.

In flow we're totally engaged in life, it's your optimal state of consciousness where you feel your best and perform your best. And over the next coming weeks you'll practice The Flow Journal System to create more flow in your life. This simple evidence-based journal system helps nudge you into flow more frequently.

Days

What are days for?

Days are where we live.

They come, they wake us

Time and time over.

They are to be happy in:

Where can we live but days?

Ah, solving that question

Brings the priest and the doctor

In their long coats

Running over the fields.

– Philip Larkin

Flow Journalling organizes consciousness so that you experience flow as often as possible and is based on proven positive psychology and is designed to fit easily into everyday life.

Flow Journalling nudges consciousness into flow in 4 simple steps.

Gratitude: In Flow gratification is not postponed, it is immediate. By training consciousness to become aware of the good in the present, living becomes it's own reward.

Set Your High Flow & High Value Priorities: Intentions are the force that keeps information in consciousness ordered. Each day you'll distinguish between what you have to do (High Value Priorities) and aligned activities that elicit flow (High Flow Priorities)

Script Your Day: Influence what enters consciousness by training your attention to notice what feedback signals to focus on, and what to ignore.

Review Your Day: You'll celebrate the small steps towards your goals and feel how positive feedback strengthens the self. And by leaning into what could have gone better you'll uncover the cause of frustration, procrastination or people pleasing and see it as an obstacle you can overcome.

HOW TO JOURNAL

Simply write. A journal is not something you get right or wrong. It's your place to organise thoughts, feelings and priorities – it's an opportunity at the start of each day to move yourself into alignment before the day commences.

If you can write a shopping list or a to-do list, you can journal.

FLOW JOURNAL

Date:

On waking: What three things are you grateful for?

1.

2.

3.

High Value Priorities

1.

2.

3.

High Flow Priorities

1.

2.

3.

Script Your Day: What will you see, hear and feel?

Review Your Day: What went well? What could have gone better?

PART II: THE COURSE



While this booklet serves as a rough guide to the course, the real learning comes from your direct experience—your thoughts, feelings, impulses and physical sensations in the present moment. The practices and processes in each session are not the learning itself but tools for reflection—an invitation to reframe how you relate to these aspects of your experience. This shift in perspective may offer insight into how certain patterns of relating can disturb your sense of peace.

The course format may vary. It could take place over eight weekly sessions of 90–120 minutes, four fortnightly sessions of 3.5 hours alternating with online sessions, or another structure entirely. However, it will always include in-person group processes, as the group dynamic is a core element of the course.

It's important to note that this course is not therapy. You are encouraged to share only what feels safe and comfortable for you.

CONTENT:

- 1. DROPPING THE BALLOON**
- 2. JOURNEY TO NOW**
- 3. COMING TO OUR SENSES**
- 4. MIND, BODY, MOVEMENT**
- 5. WHAT YOU REALLY WANT**
- 6. LEANING IN TO DIFFICULTY**
- 7. JOURNALLING FOR FLOW**
- 8. FALLING AWAKE**

1. DROPPING THE BALLOON

"Just stopping, is a radical act of sanity and love."

- Jon Kabat-Zinn

What we did.

1. Introducing CoArts
2. Meeting Ritual
3. Why are you here?
4. Dropping the Balloon
5. Three questions
6. Grounding Practice

Why we did it.

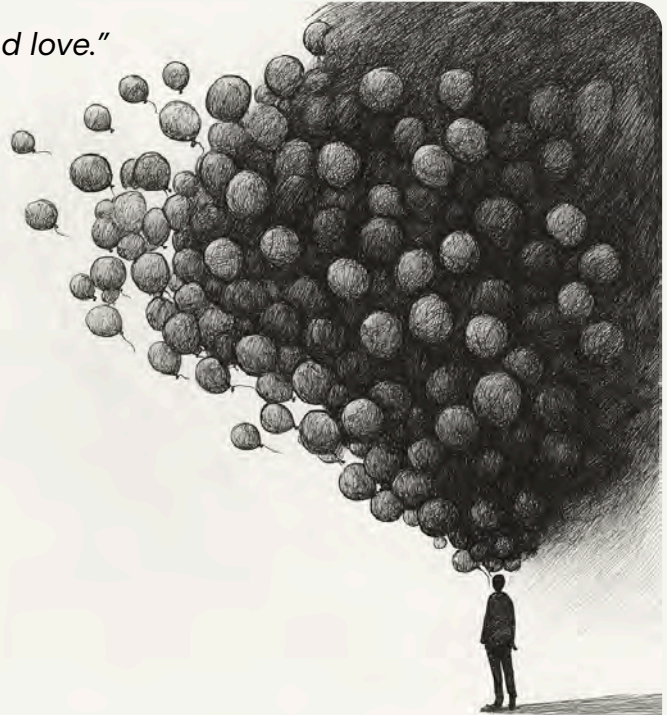
Most of us spend our waking hours playing keepy-uppy. We are juggling tasks and roles; keeping up appearances; maintaining relationships; meeting people's expectations of us, and those we have of ourselves. and on and on...

Mindfulness can sometimes feel like just another bothersome task. Sit still and upright, close your eyes, focus attention on the breath and the body, whenever the mind wanders, bring it back....another game of keepy-uppy?

In this session we tried out the 'creative challenge' of keeping up and then dropping an imaginary balloon. We then explored how our inner experience is similar, and tried dropping those balloons too. We noticed how –

1. There will always be balloons
2. But we don't always have to do something about them.
3. Rather than focus on the balloons, what happens if we focus on the hand twitching to do something about them? Can we relax the hand?

Dropping the balloon inwardly gives us the space to let our attention rest on the breath and the body. Through the **Grounding Practice**, we learned an effective way to do this and explored common obstacles we might encounter.



Home Practice

Handy Hack:

Drop the Balloon
(whenever you
notice the twitch)

Guided Practice:

Grounding
Practice (10
minutes a day)

Journaling:

Write three things
for which you are
grateful first thing
after waking up

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2. JOURNEY TO NOW

"Once you start approaching your body with curiosity rather than with fear, everything shifts."

- Bessel A. van der Kolk

What we did.

1. Grounding
2. Review of the Week
3. Journey to Now
4. Finding our Flow
5. The Seven Stations of the Spine



Why we did it.

Mindfulness is the practice of paying attention to the present moment without judgment. Unlike the mind, the body has no choice but to be present, making it a reliable anchor. As the vessel for life, it carries breath, energy, and vitality—but it also holds the imprint of our past. Our bodies "keep the score", not just from personal experience but from social conditioning and inherited genetics. Though always in the present, they generate unconscious impulses that pull the mind away, leading to patterns of avoidance. Over time, this struggle manifests as physical clenching, reinforcing numbness and tension that disconnect us from awareness.

Our creative challenge was to map our journey to now and notice how revisiting our past terrain triggers patterns of clenching. We then witnessed abstract depictions of others' journeys, evoking a sense of shared experience. Compassion works the same way—it is all-encompassing or absent. That's why self-compassion is a misnomer; true compassion extends to all.

We ended the session with another journey—this time through the body, moving along the seven stations of the spine. With a friendly, curious attention, we simply allowed sensations to be as they were, practicing unclenching, breathing, and softening into presence.

Home Practice

Handy Hack:

Unclench and
Breathe

Guided Practice:

Seven Stations of
the Spine
(20 minutes a day)

Journaling:

3 Gratitudes +
3 High Flow
Priorities (HFP)

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3. COMING TO OUR SENSES

Being aware of the sound of the bell does not mean the bell belongs to you. Likewise being aware of thoughts does not mean the thoughts belong to you.

- Wu Sin

What we did.

1. Seven Stations of the Spine
2. Review of the week
3. Three Precious Pills
4. Coming to our Senses
5. The Sense of Being Alive



Why we did it.

In our previous session, we explored our life experiences and physical bodies. This time, we delved into the realm of our senses: touch, taste, smell, sight, hearing, thoughts, and emotions.

Consider this: what if thoughts and emotions were also considered senses? What if they were energies arising within the physical environment of our bodies and brains, rather than originating from a non-physical entity known as the self, like a ghost in the machine?

If this were the case, who would we be if not the awareness of all these occurrences? And where would this awareness reside?

By allowing ourselves to be guided blindfolded through a carefully designed sensory journey by a trusted colleague, we catch a glimpse of this timeless and spaceless awareness, which is our true nature.

Another method to access this calm abiding is by taking the three precious pills. When we ingest the white pill, we become aware of the stillness within our bodies. Upon consuming the red pill, we become conscious of silence, and upon consuming the blue pill, we become conscious of our expansiveness.

It's important to note that there's no risk of overdosing or experiencing side effects from these pills!

Home Practice

Handy Hack:

The Three
Precious Pills

Guided Practice:

The Sense of Being
Alive
(20 minutes a day)

Journaling:

3 Gratitudes +
3 HFP +
3 High Value
Priorities (HVP)

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4. BODY, MOVEMENT, MIND

'Experience this one thing for what it is, not what you think it is. Be open to what the world is telling you. Life is nothing more than a stream of experiences – the more widely and deeply you swim in it, the richer your life will be.

- Mihaly Csikszentmihalyi

What we did.

1. The Sense of Being Alive
2. Review of the week
3. Chaos Game
4. Our First Movement
5. Hour of the day
6. Body, Movement and Mind



Why we did it.

Meditation is to mindfulness what a workout is to fitness. The repeated practice of bringing the mind back to a focal point actively rewires the brain, strengthening metacognition—our ability to notice the impulses of avoidance and craving that drive much of our behavior and thought processes.

Mindfulness begins with noticing these impulses and then opening up to the pleasant and unpleasant thoughts, feelings, and sensations behind them, rather than reacting automatically. But meditation doesn't have to mean stillness, as our practices so far have shown. In fact, movement can make these patterns even more noticeable. When we bring awareness to the body in motion, we begin to see how our movements are shaped by habitual patterns of tension and clenching.

A simple game showed how much fun it can be to have a body! We then explored how it is also just plain beautiful, through a simple, repeated physical gesture—opening and closing—the first movement we ever performed. Performance is key here, not in the sense of pretending, but in the act of being observed with compassion by a partner. Performance, in this context, means bringing open, non-judgmental awareness to our own movements.

We then mimed a typical day, paying attention to when we open to experience and when we close. What thoughts and feelings accompany these actions? What happens if we consciously open to what we usually resist—or close to what we habitually embrace?

Home Practice

Handy Hack:

Exploring opening and closing

Guided Practice:

Body, Movement, Mind
(15 minutes a day)

Journaling:

3 Gratitudes +
3 HFP +
3 HVP

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5. WHAT YOU REALLY WANT

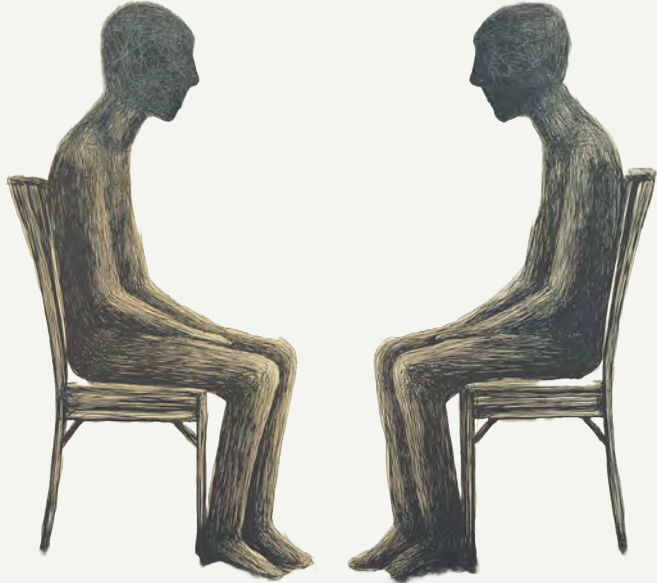
When I look inside and see that I am nothing, that is wisdom. When I look outside and see that I am everything, that is love.

And between these two, my life turns.

- Nisargadatta

What we did.

1. Mind, Body, Movement
2. 50:50 Listening
3. Review of the week
4. OK Corral
5. What Do You Really Want?
6. What if all there is is this?



Why we did it.

Paying attention to the body reveals patterns of sensation that signal where we hold stress, just as observing our thoughts and emotions helps us recognize and release negative patterns before they shape our mood or actions. Likewise, maintaining 50% of our attention on the breath and body during interactions allows mindfulness to become part of daily life. This practice also helps us notice the 'life positions' and old 'scripts' that no longer serve us.

In this week's first Creative Challenge, The OK Corral, we explored how 'life positions' shape our perceptions of ourselves and others. In the second challenge, What Do You Really Want?, we examined the constant craving that keeps us trapped in a cycle of seeking.

All life operates through feedback loops. Most of our brain works unconsciously to maintain homeostasis and allostasis, keeping us in what we perceive as the 'Goldilocks zone.' But in humans, this process has a strange twist—a Möbius strip—where we keep meeting ourselves from the other side, endlessly feeling somehow divided and incomplete. Yet, in our happiest moments, when we want for nothing, there is no experiencer—only the experience itself. This is the flow state.

Since the start of the course, you've been practicing gratitude—the first step in creating the conditions for flow. We explored how gratitude shifts awareness to the happiness already present, allowing us to fully engage with life from a place of inner harmony.

Home Practice

Handy Hack:

Watch the want

Guided Practice:

What if All there is is this?

(15 minutes a day)

Journaling:

3 Gratitudes +

3 HFP +

3 HVP

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6. LEANING IN TO DIFFICULTY

If you want the rainbow, you got to put up with the rain.

- Steven Wright

What we did.

1. What if all there is is this?
2. Review of the week
3. 5 Elements Practice
4. The Gold in the Wound
5. Mirror Illusion
6. Turning towards the Difficult

Why we did it.

Emotions are probably one of the most misunderstood elements of our human experience. Animals have five basic emotions that are triggered in reaction to 'in the moment' environmental or physiological stimuli. In their automatic expressions they serve as signals with very specific functions.

Anger – Get out of my way

Sadness – I need comforting

Joy – This feels good

Disgust – Get that away from me

Fear – I need help

In the human, because we have created a character with a future and a past, that environment also includes our psyche with all its memories and projections on what might be happening and what others might be thinking and feeling. Now, in the past and in the future! Hence all the drama!

When we bring our attention to discomfort in the body, we start to notice the contours of our clenched-ness, 'our wounds.'

Surprisingly, when allowed to 'speak' they have a story to tell that have emotional components. Even those that have purely physical causes.

One of the most difficult things is to welcome and feel gratitude for discomfort and yet in doing so we can be more at ease with our suffering, or even find that when we offer no resistance to our suffering it becomes joy.



Home Practice

Handy Hack:

The 5 Elements

Guided Practice:

Turning Towards
the Difficult

(15 minutes a day)

Journaling:

3 Gratitudes +

3 HFP +

3 HVP

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7. FINDING YOUR FLOW

A joyful life is an individual creation that cannot be copied from a recipe.

- Mihaly Csikszentmihalyi

What we did.

1. Turning Towards Discomfort
2. Review of the week
3. Attention Budget
4. Filling Your Consciousness
5. The Art of Reflection
6. Overview of The Flow Journal System
7. The Four Pillars



Why we did it.

This week, we challenged you to see that every moment is a creative challenge. As we like to say, *CoArts is a creative movement towards awareness of the creative movement of awareness!*

If life is theatre and we're not writing the script—who is? Our habits, conditioning, and circumstances often shape our experience without us realizing it. Attention is our most powerful tool, yet in the "Attention Economy," it's constantly being pulled away.

That's why we asked: What do I truly want to experience today? If we're not choosing where our attention goes, then who—or what—is? Through The Flow Journal System, we explored how scripting—writing down what we expect to see, hear, and feel—helps direct our awareness intentionally.

We also practiced detached reflection, stepping back to notice what serves us, recognizing progress, and embracing joy. Nightly reflection deepens this awareness, reconnecting us with our true essence.

If this is all theatre, then scripting isn't about control—it's about waking up to the roles we play, the stories we tell, and the choices we make. Every moment invites us into awareness. Every moment is a creative challenge.

Home Practice

Handy Hack:

Scripting &
Reflecting

Guided Practice:

The Four Pillars
(20 minutes a day)

Journaling:

Full Flow Journal
System

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8. FALLING AWAKE

The bad news is you're falling through the air, nothing to hang on to, no parachute. The good news is, there's no ground.

- Chogyam Trungpa

What we did.

1. The Four Pillar Practice
2. Sensory Questionnaire
3. Sensory Poem
4. Great Smile Practice
5. Closing Circle
6. Meeting ritual



Why we did it.

In our final session together, we embraced one last creative challenge—writing and performing a poem in front of the group. For many, this felt like standing on the edge of a precipice and being asked to jump. Yet, over the past eight weeks, the trust and care within the group became a safety net, holding each person with unconditional positive regard.

This course has been an invitation to play with the possibility of awakening—to fall in love, gently and courageously, with ‘what is.’ Through a series of creative challenges as embodied signposts and a journaling method to navigate the edges of awareness, we explored what it means to be truly present.

Often, we soften life’s edges with creature comforts—a glass of wine, a good film, or other coping mechanisms. But mindfulness, as taught here, is not about coping. It has invited you to sit on that edge, dangle your feet over the abyss, and notice, despite everything...it’s not so bad!

In the Welsh language, there are two words for peace—*heddwch* and *tangnefedd*. The first seeks the absence of conflict, a peace that papers over the cracks. The second is the peace of heaven, where all things are well, and all manner of things are well just as they are. In the Great Smile practice we explored what this second peace might feel like by venturing out into the ‘heavens’ and returning to the heart of the matter.

We then ended as we began, with the meeting ritual.

Home Practice

Handy Hack:

Great Smile

Guided Practice:

The Four Pillars
(20 minutes a day)

Journaling:

Full Flow Journal
System

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PART III: TRAVELLING LIGHTER



Congratulations on completing the course!

In this final section, we introduce The Four Pillars—a practice designed to strengthen the core aspects of wellbeing, as identified by renowned neuroscientist Prof. Richard Davidson. Think of it as a kind of mental cross-training for your health and resilience.

We also share how you can continue benefiting from the course by joining our growing community of practice, Travelling Lighter.

Immediately after the course, you may feel uplifted—like the sky's the limit. However, the deep-seated patterns of craving, avoidance, and ignorance are ingrained in our psyche and reinforced by a culture that often amplifies them.

You may have glimpsed your true nature, allowing you to move more lightly through the world. Some experiences might feel difficult to share with those around you.

Regularly connecting and practicing with others who have walked the same path can be valuable—but there is absolutely no obligation to do so.

CONTENT:

1. THE FOUR PILLARS
2. WHAT NEXT?
3. DECODING THE KEY

THE FOUR PILLARS

OF MENTAL HEALTH

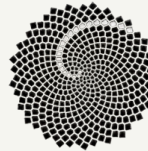
By now, we hope you've solved the murder mystery that opened this course—or at least gained insight into what disrupts your peace. The usual suspects are *craving*, *avoidance*, and *ignorance of our true nature*—each playing a role in the crime. A confession from any one of them goes a long way in undoing their hold on us.

While this experiential understanding helps you move through life with greater ease, we have also been strengthening neural circuits to support a more balanced and mindful way of being—something the world needs now more than ever.

The *Four Pillars* guided practice integrates these key elements into a concise 20-minute session, helping you continuously strengthen the foundation of your mental well-being.



FOCUS



FLOW



OUTLOOK



COMPASSION



WHAT NEXT?



We really hope you've had a great time and gained a lot from the course. We also wish that you keep benefiting from what you've learned and stay curious about exploring your true nature through the creative challenges. We'd love to keep supporting you on your journey into creative mindfulness and Context Oriented Arts.

Theatr Cynefin is inviting you to be part of a growing community of people who, like you, have completed one of our CoArts courses. We have regular online drop-in sessions with different CoArts trainers and monthly guest speakers from the non-duality tradition – some of whom have fully embraced those glimpses as their whole perspective!

We also share details about training opportunities, new guided practices, and chances for one-on-one coaching. To join *Travelling Lighter*, simply scan the QR code above.



For More Information
Contact

Theatr Cynefin
info@cynefin.org
www.cynefin.org

DECODING THE KEY

We've placed this key at the back of the book for easy reference throughout the course. It unlocks the human algorithm, shedding light on the roots of our agitation. Remember, understanding it isn't a directive for change or acceptance; it's merely a lens to view the mechanism of human behavior, backed by recent insights from psychology and neuroscience.

Perceptions resemble the images seen in a mirror. What they see forms our complete reality, while in truth, only the mirror of consciousness truly exists.

Ideas and thoughts resemble balloons; appealing yet fundamentally devoid of substance. Yet we feel compelled to keep them up. Why?

The Mobius loop at the key's heart symbolises the self or rather the **selfing action**. While we see ourselves as the drivers of our actions, we are actually propelled around a continuous loop of craving, aversion, and ignorance. The ignorance is of our true nature, glimpses of which can ease the restlessness.



Our **physical body** resembles a tightly clenched bottle. To fit into this chaotic society, we've had to twist and dull various aspects of ourselves. As adults, we firmly secure the lid. However, when we unclench and breathe, we create room for healing—both for ourselves and for society.

Emotions function like a sleep mask, influencing much of our behavior while we remain unaware of their presence. Those we are aware of we call feelings, but they are usually what the mind accepts as being part of our identity.